

Adjective order

Teaching guide

Describe an object naturally without overloading the sentence.

Understand the distinction

When several adjectives come before a noun, English tends to put opinion before more factual descriptions. A useful common order is opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose, then noun.

This is a tendency, not a requirement to use every category. Meaning, emphasis, and established phrases can affect order. Two or three well-chosen adjectives are usually clearer than a long stack. Use a dictionary or a natural example if an order feels uncertain.

Compare the patterns

OPINION + SIZE

a lovely small cafe

An opinion comes before size.

AGE + MATERIAL

an old wooden chair

Age comes before material.

COLOR + ORIGIN

a blue Italian jacket

Color normally comes before origin.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Put in a natural order: bag / leather / small / a

2. Put in order: wooden / old / an / table

3. Must every description include all adjective categories?

Use it in your own life

Describe an object using two useful adjectives.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. a small leather bag

Size normally comes before material.

2. an old wooden table

Age normally comes before material.

3. No. Choose only useful details.

The order is guidance for the adjectives you need.

One possible response

I keep my notes in a small blue notebook.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-10.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe an object using two useful adjectives.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.